

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 5

Resisting with Joy ~ Acceptance

10 May 2026



Children of the Himalayas

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Norton Wisdom, Guest Artist

Improvisation on W ZLOBIE LEZY and REGENT SQUARE

L'Ascension (Olivier Messiaen)

- Majesté du Christ demandant sa gloire à son Père
- Alleluias sereins d'une âme qui désire le ciel
- Transports de joie d'une âme devant la gloire du Christ qui est la sienne
- Prière du Christ montant vers son Père

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Lauren Seely & Rev. Lehman

We give thanks for the life that beats within us:
breath and heartbeat, joy and sorrow, dance and stillness.

We give thanks for the life that ebbs and flows between us:
loving, understanding, creating, embracing, and letting go.

We give thanks for the web of life that surrounds and sustains us:
feeding, protecting, teaching, and inspiring mutual care.

We give thanks for the Source of all life:
in this living universe, of which our lives are expressions.
[ILawton.c3Exch]

In this place we remember...

*Life is an indescribable gift.
Our gathering in this sacred place
is a celebration of that gift.
So let us celebrate the richness and diversity of life!*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Alleluia! Hear God's Story

W ZLOBIE LEZY

Alleluia! Hear God's story, still unfolding with each dawn.
Taste the wine and body broken: God's creative love lives on.
Who the neighbor? Who the hungry? Who is thirsty for shalom?
God of journey, in our story; lead us, with the neighbor, home.

Alleluia! Sing the story; God's great faithfulness proclaim.
Tell of prophets and apostles; sing the power of Jesus' name.
Who the neighbor? Who the listener? Who has ears to hear our song?
God of history tune our voices, make our hopeful witness strong.

Alleluia! Sing the story; every sinew now engage.
Tethered close in truthful worship, boldly face the coming age.
Who the neighbor? Who the watchful? Who will welcome life's embrace?
God of Gospel, tell the story through our dancing of your grace.
-lyrics Mary Anne Parrott, 1986

Prayer of Awareness

Rev. Lehman

Loving God,
in the midst of the light
and newness of this day,
many of our faces are lined with worry;
our days are full of stress and struggle.
Yet we come to this time
grateful that in the midst of the uncertainty of our lives,
hope and joy are ever present.

Surprise us now with your presence;
renew our sense of wonder;
keep us open to the gift of your spirit,
present in our singing, praying, speaking, and living. [jamienorwichmcclennan]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"God Is Gone Up"
Cathedral Choir

GERALD FINZI

***The Lord's Prayer**

Lauren Seely

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*
John Philip Newell
Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Peace in the longing,
peace in the leaving,
peace in the letting go.
In every step peace.

Today
now
this moment
may we see
the presence of God
in the face of another
and, in our seeing,
may we find life. [adapt/jrichardson]
This morning, may the peace of God be with all of you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Lauren Seely

From the Gospel of Luke, chapter 24

Then Jesus took them to the outskirts of Bethany, and with upraised hands blessed the disciples. While blessing them, the savior left them and was carried up to heaven. The disciples worshiped the risen Christ and returned to Jerusalem full of joy. They were found in the Temple constantly, speaking the praises of God.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal God,
we give thanks that in all time and space
we are held by your love.
When we find ourselves in the midst of joy,
help us to remember to be thankful.

When we are confronted with hardship and loss,
may we remember that we are never alone.
When there are moments we simply cannot understand,
remind us to look for your comfort and reassurance
through the love of those who hold us dear,
whether they are near or far away.
And then, Holy One,
help us to remember the words
spoken so long ago
by Mother Julian of Norwich...

*All shall be well,
and all shall be well,
and all manner of things
shall be well.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"Adoramus Te" from *Via Crucis*
Laude

PATRICK CASSIDY

*"We adore you, Christ, and we bless you, because through your holy life
and sacrifice you have redeemed the world."*

Sermon

Acceptance ~ The Only Place Where Change Can Begin

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

*On this day
and on all the days to come,
may the love of Christ
be our center, our focus,
our practice, our feast.*

Prayer of Blessing

O God, we know
that this food we are about to share
has already been blessed
by you
by those who planted it
by those who tended it
by those who gathered it
by those who prepared it.

So bless us, O God,
that we may taste and know
its blessedness
as we feast with one another
at this table you have prepared.

[jrichardson]

*We pray this in the name
of the Christ, whose table
we now share.
Amen and Amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Lauren Seely

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

In those wobbly moments of doubt
when useless fear invades ferociously,
in those extended heart-pilgrimages
of searching and sobering discontent,
in those patterns of old behavior
that refuse efforts to be shaken off,
in those troubling, hurtful relationships
and ongoing disillusionments of life,
we have you with us, Great Companion,
to assure us that we do not travel alone.

-Joyce Rupp

Offertory

"Geistliches Lied"
Cathedral Choir

JOHANNES BRAHMS

*"Let nothing afflict you with grief; Be calm, with God's blessing, that relieves willfulness
and brings contentment. Why worry about tomorrow? The God who has given you life
watches over all. Be steadfast in everything. Release into God's divine being and walk into truth."*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Lauren Seely

May your goodness, O God, help bring the gifts we give this morning to life:
As new hope for healing;
As fresh ways of coping;
As a chance to rest;
As a chance to work;
As a way to live joyfully and gratefully.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.
Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

In the leaving
in the letting go
let there be this
to hold onto
at the last:

the enduring of love
the remembering of joy
the persisting of hope
the offering of gratitude
the receiving of grace
the blessing of peace.

Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

"I'll Fly Away"
Cathedral Choir

ALBERT E. BRUMLEY, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come and Feast, for All are Welcomed

REGENT SQUARE

Come and feast, for all are welcomed at God's table spread with love.
Come proclaim God's grace and goodness in, around us, and above.
Come and feast for all are welcome at God's table spread with love.

Here we nurture and encourage as we share this common meal,
While we foster deep communion and our inner selves reveal.
Here we nurture and encourage as we share this common meal.

See the chalice lifted upward; smell the fragrant, broken bread;
Taste the gifts from field and vineyard; hear the words that Jesus said:
'Eat and drink, and in remembrance touch your souls with wine and bread.'

With the Spirit blessed commission, 'Go and serve this meal to all,'
Take its love and peaceful vision into every banquet hall.
Go and serve as nourished people, gladly feeding one and all!

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Transports de joie – Reprise (Olivier Messiaen)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"Today we celebrate Ascension Sunday with music focused on accepting and letting go. Gerald Finzi's music represents some of the most integrated choral/organ music in the repertoire. His "God Is Gone Up," written for Ascension, brings us into that release. Brahms' "Geistliches Lied" echoes the calm that

Jesus left with his followers as he left them. The Carter's "I'll Fly Away" speaks for itself as an effusive reminder of the impermanence of life. We have a special relationship with Patrick Cassidy that has led to some fruitful musical creations. In 2021 Laude released the premiere recording of Patrick's "The Mass" for choir and organ, and the following year the Cathedral Choir presented the work live. The album now has over a million and a half listens on Spotify, and is available if you haven't had a chance to listen. Two years ago we premiered his "Magnificat" which has also been well received in the listening expanses. We have the great privilege of working with Patrick on his new major work "Via Crucis," which we are planning to premiere next spring. From now until then we'll sing a few movements when they align with our services. We'll all get to be a part of the long-form creation of a major work for choir and orchestra as we witness its growth and be the ears to welcome its presence for the first time. The "Via Crucis" is an experiential mandala of sorts with fourteen stations. Each station reflects a moment of Jesus' journey toward crucifixion. It is intended to give us a process for reflection and meditation on the horrors and redemption of that day. Ultimately, we are invited to grow into understanding acceptance, sacrifice, and grace in the face of circumstances out of our control. Through Patrick's research on the various text sources for the "Via Crucis", he has found Latin texts that align with the progressive theology of First Church. This work will be unique in the choral repertoire for a number of reasons that reflect who we are as a community of faith. Today we'll sing the "Adoramus Te," which is the final movement. From the first music of Patrick's that I ever heard, I was aware of his capacious patience as a composer. He is the only composer I know that regularly writes tempi where the quarter note moves slower than 40 clicks. He lets lines slowly unfold before repeating them or molding them into a slightly different shape. This patience leads to a full-bodied release of energy. The trick lies in settling into the moment and letting the phrases wash over you. At their core, Patrick's pieces are acceptance. The persistence of this final movement of a work that centers acceptance and release anchors the meaning of the whole experience. After participating in a meditative journey like the "Via Crucis," we are left more receptive to what is, and to our place among it all. Instead of a grand Easter-like celebration, these inward-focused walks teach us about uncovering and opening to the great mysteries of existence."